MONTHLY UPDATE

Kenya: monthly update, September – October 2026

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> *Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.*

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

Kenya signed the Digital Cooperation Organization's charter as a signatory member, reported on 28 September. The central bank licensed 29 more digital credit providers on 30 September, bringing the total to 281. Interviews for the next Data Protection Commissioner are set for 5 October. An Indian IT firm's sovereign cloud was announced live at a Nairobi data centre, and the largest operator put M-PESA tap-to-pay on 30,000 point-of-sale terminals. The Ardhisasa land platform went down again on 21 September.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Government communication was centralised. The broadcasting principal secretary described a newly adopted National Communication Policy built on 'One Government, One Voice', with a National Communication Centre to collate, validate and release state information; the final text is dated 22 January 2026. No budget or staffing for the centre is published.

Legislation and regulation

The fifteen draft communications regulations went through a three-day stakeholder validation workshop convened by the ICT ministry with the regulator, reported on 23 September; the remaining statutory stages are still to come. Public comment on the National Payment System Bill runs to 9 October, on a law firm's account of the notice. Regulations for non-deposit-taking credit providers were gazetted, revoking the 2022 digital credit rules, with separate consent for personal data and human review of AI lending decisions.

Data protection

The regulator's 2026 guidance notes on cross-border transfers add standard contractual clauses and a binding-corporate-rules application form to the April note. The document prints no issue date.

The Public Service Commission shortlisted 13 of 152 applicants to succeed the inaugural data commissioner at the end of her six-year term, among them the Media Council's chief executive and the senior deputy data commissioner; interviews are set for 5 October. The High Court ordered the largest operator on 18 September to give a subscriber, within 21 days, the particulars of every request to access or disclose her communications and mobile money data and the access logs it holds, under the constitutional right of access to information; compliance is not on record. The regulator told a parliamentary committee that deactivation and recycling of inactive numbers now run under its 2026 procedures and safeguards.

Regional collaboration

The continental data convention still has no Kenyan signature behind it. A high-level parliamentary dialogue on accession was called for 7 September 2026. What has moved is the process, not the treaty position, and no instrument of accession is on the record.

On 21 September the ICT cabinet secretary proposed that willing African Union states jointly test one cross-border public service and report by February 2027, citing eCitizen and the interoperability framework. No state is on record as joining.

The ICT cabinet secretary signed the Digital Cooperation Organization's Charter in New York during the UN General Assembly, reported on 28 September, making Kenya a Signatory Member and one of eight approved candidates whose accession would take membership from 16 to 24 countries. Neither the signing date nor the date accession completes is given.

Standards

The technology authority put the National Information Security Framework's audit, risk-management and certification toolkits to a stakeholder workshop in Nairobi, reported on 7 September, to test whether they are practical before critical information infrastructure is certified. The central bank said its AI survey will feed a guidance note for the banking sector on data and AI governance, risk mitigation and third-party vendors; no draft or date is published.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The Digital Superhighway's procurement went to court and lost. On 4 September the High Court quashed the 2024 advisory opinion of the Attorney-General that had cleared payments connected to the Sh15bn Nightigale tender, and referred the conflict-of-interest question to the anti-corruption commission. The challenge came from a consumer federation, which had contested the award of two 2022-23 tenders and the payment made to the communications regulator's former chairperson on the strength of that opinion. The judgment itself is not held, and no response from the agencies or the Attorney-General is on file — but the opinion that stood behind the payments no longer does.

Finance

New investments

The World Bank's digital acceleration project was reviewed on 14 September: more than 62,000 teachers trained and more than 5,000 smart boards distributed, reaching nearly 100,000 students, with disbursement delays raised. The operation closes in October 2028.

Under the DigiKen programme a commercial bank and the UN Capital Development Fund launched a USD 900,000 loan portfolio guarantee backing up to USD 1.8m of lending to fintechs, digital credit providers, e-commerce firms and innovation hubs, covering half of principal and 70 per cent in arid and semi-arid counties. No loan under it is reported yet.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The government fibre programme was measured against its own deadline for the first time. The ICT Cabinet Secretary put 37,000km installed against the 100,000km target serving 53,000 government facilities, leaving 63,000km outstanding months before the 2027 deadline; the programme was announced in November 2022 and split in 2023 into 52,000km for government and 48,000km for private companies, with Sh940.6m paid to the power utility by June 2025. The same account puts broadband subscriptions at 52.85 million by March 2026 against 22.08 million in June 2020, fixed internet at 2.66 million, 4G population coverage at 73.4% and 5G at 3.04%. The 37,000km is the minister's own figure and no route or county breakdown stands behind it.

On the delivery side of the same programme, coordination was stepped up rather than the schedule revised: two principal secretaries began co-chairing a standing review of the implementing agencies on 4 September, the coordination framed against a target of taking the technology industry from US$7bn to US$100bn. No revised delivery date came with it, and 63,000km of the 100,000km fibre target remains outstanding before the 2027 deadline.

One wholesale fibre entrant is leaving. Airtel is winding up its Kenyan fibre subsidiary after two years, having returned its facilities licence.

The backbone went back to tender. The ICT Authority issued framework agreements for national backbone links and cross-border and metro links under the World Bank-financed digital economy project, each for three years extendable by two, with Treasury putting public-sector fibre at 30,454km in 2026 against 22,486km in 2022. No award is held.

The Communications Authority called stakeholders to an online validation forum on 30 September to finalise its draft guidelines for commercial internet telephony services, having published the consultation responses and its position on each. The draft text is not held.

Data Storage

One build opened rather than slipping. The operator of the largest colocation campus added 6.4MW at a second Nairobi facility on 7 September, and retired the iColo brand in Kenya and Mozambique in favour of its parent's. The figure is critical IT load rather than delivered live load, and no occupancy, customer count or campus total is published.

Two cloud platforms opened in Nairobi in September: Nobus opened an availability zone, and Tata Consultancy Services announced its sovereign cloud live on iXAfrica's campus on 28 September, delivered with the integrator Sybyl, with its capacity and pricing undisclosed. Oracle was still preparing its Nairobi region at the same campus.

Energy

On 24 September a Rockefeller Foundation accelerator announced five Kenyan sites to test computing load as the anchor customer for new solar-plus-storage mini-grids serving about 50,000 people, with community demand given priority over compute. No site, developer, capacity or start date is named.

Technical Capacity

The advanced science and technology institute, its operationalisation under review with the Korean export credit agency in August, was stated completed at US$94m by the Treasury principal secretary in Seoul on 10 September, with no opening, intake or operating budget published.

Cybersecurity

The standards the new agency will enforce were put to the people who would have to work them. The technology authority tested the National Information Security Framework's audit, risk-management and certification mechanisms at a Nairobi workshop, to establish whether they are practical for national implementation ahead of certifying critical information infrastructure. Neither the framework text nor the certification criteria nor the list of infrastructure to be certified is published.

The government's scorecard reported the director-general recruited and deployed, board seats and technical posts still being filled, and the agency not yet fully operational, and two board members were then gazetted with effect from 11 September. The prosecutor's office meanwhile issued a reference guide setting out each offence under the cybercrimes Act with its elements, required evidence, sample charges and court application templates. The communications minister told the Senate that the national incident response centre's forensics laboratory had received more than 200 requests, most involving online abuse.

DPI

Data Exchange

The head of the public service convened the examinations council, the public service commission and the education ministry to link academic credential databases directly to hiring agencies, against fake certificates. No design or date is set.

The President announced Masterkey, a wallet for verifiable qualification and work records across African borders whose first phase targets 150,000 placements with Kenya, Ghana and Rwanda, Kenya leading the first national implementation through eCitizen. He said the system will not itself award jobs, visas or professional recognition; no cost or launch date is stated.

The back end became the stated priority. The ICT principal secretary said a unified operations platform linking systems through secure APIs is being built, ahead of AI agents in service delivery, and the ICT secretary described the back end as still largely manual and the interoperability platform as still in development; no budget or date is published. The social protection project sought a consultant to upgrade the Enhanced Single Registry and the community development information system to exchange data with the health authority, the social security fund and the population register, under World Bank procurement.

The electoral commission is moving its voter-registration targets from census estimates to registration-bureau and immigration data on issued identity cards and passports, against a target of 6.3 million new voters for 2027.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The hospital-to-registry birth notification system, launched in June, registered more than 270,000 newborns and assigned each a unique personal identifier within two months, according to the immigration and citizen services department, which also put national identity cards issued between January and September 2026 at 2.4 million. Integration with the health ministry's hospital management system and a death e-notification system are planned; no facility count or county coverage is published.

The registration bureau said more than 600,000 people who could not previously get identity cards have been registered since extra vetting in border counties was scrapped, and rights groups asked that the removal be made permanent. A National Assembly committee found identity registration in Bungoma held back by shortages of staff, vehicles, equipment and connectivity, with more live-capture kits awaited. The immigration principal secretary said electronic birth notification will reach every insurer-contracted hospital by December 2026.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The platforms Kenyans use to be paid changed their rules one after another over the past year: an international payments provider imposed restrictions, a domestic dollar-banking service withdrew that product, a remittance operator paused its wallet and a streaming platform cut monetisation. Four separate commercial decisions rather than a regulatory change; no user numbers, values or regulator response are held.

The regulator's June-quarter return put mobile money subscriptions at 54,005,800, up 1.2 per cent in the quarter, while registered agents fell from 602,470 to 568,463. Subscriptions count accounts, not people.

Tanzania's competition regulator put KCB Group's stake in the payments company Pesapal at 22.23% in a notice of 21 August, the first public figure for a deal announced in November 2025; the price is undisclosed and approval is pending.

An independent switch launched a domestic card scheme on 22 September for banks to issue physical and virtual cards across its ATMs, point-of-sale terminals and agents. No issuing institution, consumer date or price is disclosed.

The central bank licensed 29 more digital credit providers on 30 September, taking the total to 281 from more than 900 applications since March 2022, with 9,596,509 loans worth KSh165.1bn made by licensed lenders by August. A tier-one bank's fintech arm launched a wallet that sends to mobile-money services and bank accounts; no user figure is published. An industry association reported the bank-owned instant payment switch's chief executive saying a portable account identifier is ready and institutions must begin mapping customers to it.

Registries

The lands ministry announced a fresh outage of the Ardhisasa land platform on 21 September 2026; users asked for an explanation, a restoration timeline and an assurance of no penalties. The communications regulator hosted Lesotho's regulator on 2 September to benchmark the national addressing system, whose bill has been in committee since April 2026.

Sectoral management information systems

The claims platform was quantified from the settlement end for the first time. The health ministry and the counties jointly put settlement at 78% across all 47 counties with KSh 159.3bn paid, and reconciliation and sign-off completed for legacy insurance-fund claims, at an intergovernmental budget council session on 31 August. It is their own joint figure, published without a denominator, an ageing profile or a rejection breakdown.

The education register failed its first money test. The principal secretary told the Public Accounts Committee in late August that the latest capitation round used neither the new system nor its predecessor but manually verified data, because the new system is incomplete; schools reported failed logins and unsaved submissions during the Grade 10 selection it was required for, and MPs had already flagged KES 103.99bn paid against unverified numbers on the old one.

The health authority made a functioning electronic medical records system a condition of provider contracts for the cycle opening 1 October and running to June 2029, with onboarding only through its central digital platform. The health ministry extended to 30 October the deadline for public level 5 and 6, faith-based and private facilities to move from the health insurer's provider portal to the health management information system: 6,427 county public facilities have moved, and 38 of 518 contracted faith-based facilities. The health minister said the change makes each facility's own system the primary one, exchanging data with the insurer's systems, and that 28 existing hospital platforms have been certified. The health ministry and the governors' health committee agreed that current facility contracts will not be extended again and set contracting clinics in every county to 14 October. The health ministry put migration at 6,427 public, 38 private and 38 of 518 faith-based facilities.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The election system's own procurement was sent back. The electoral commission had said the tenders were temporarily halted after a request for review, with the Register of Voters to undergo a 30-day biometric verification and an independent audit before certification; on 4 September the review board ordered it to correct and re-publish the tender, finding it disclosed neither the methodology and objective benchmarks for the 100-point technical evaluation nor the evidence establishing compliance with mandatory requirements, ownership or manufacturer authorisation, and directing it to take advice from the procurement regulator and allow bidders not less than seven days. The board rejected a claim that the specifications were tailored to one supplier.

On the one citizen survey held, digital-government adoption stands at 49% and net satisfaction fell five points from 2024 to 64%, with 12% of users reporting no problems, the lowest share of 44 countries surveyed.

Cargo seals left state hands. The revenue authority approved 15 private vendors for electronic seals on transit cargo and set 26 October 2026 for retiring its own, with users choosing and contracting their vendor directly under the regional cargo tracking system.

At the UN General Assembly the ICT cabinet secretary put eCitizen at more than 22,500 services. The government, the UN in Kenya and a commercial bank signed a declaration of intent on 20 September for a Kenya Diaspora Impact Platform, a digital gateway to verifiable investment opportunities; no launch date or cost is given.

The High Court at Marsabit dismissed on 5 October 2026 a constitutional petition against mandatory travel health insurance for foreign visitors, holding the claim that insurance data collected through the electronic travel authorisation system was insecure to be generalised and unproven. The Senate's ICT committee questioned the transport authority's director general on 8 October over the Instant Fines Traffic Management System, whose automated penalties the High Court halted on 12 March 2026 and whose launch notice the authority withdrew on 27 March.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Nakuru County deployed a case management and reporting platform for survivors of gender-based violence and for services to persons with disabilities, replacing paper records, funded by Lithuanian development cooperation; no user or case count is published. The Controller of Budget reported that counties paid at least Sh8.3 billion in salaries through manual payrolls outside the human resource information system in the year to 30 June 2026, a year past the deadline to migrate; Nakuru processed Sh1.86 billion that way, and Narok and Trans Nzoia none.

Rural digital data capture

Rural digitalisation arrived as a marketplace rather than an office. Mkulima Bora, built by a private developer with a German development agency and Rift Valley county governments, connects smallholders directly with bulk buyers and verified input suppliers, with search by county, sub-county and ward, a map view, negotiated offers and logistics booking. It is built on reusable components and open standards rather than as a closed system, so that registration, consent management, registries, messaging and scheduling connect to existing government infrastructure. The account is the standards initiative's own, and it states no county list, user count or public funding.

Technology

AI

A model provider disclosed that it had removed a domestic actor's account mass-producing posts in batches of 50, praising the energy minister's tariff decision and claiming the opposition was fracturing ahead of 2027, with no reach established; the minister denied any ministry role. The state's own compute moved a step: a Letter of Agreement with the UN development agency commits to operationalising sovereign AI infrastructure at the Konza Data Centre, and the Treasury describes the Konza Digital Media City as recently approved for Korean financing.

The Kenya Medical Research Institute is a partner in openScopes AIDDiA, a four-year, GBP 4.4m Wellcome Trust-funded programme led by the University of Cape Town that pairs open-source microscopes with machine-learning image analysis for infectious-disease research, which held its kick-off from 7 to 11 September.

At the UN General Assembly Kenya co-hosted the launch of a 2026-2027 roadmap for children's rights and protection in the age of AI, backed by 23 states and eight UN entities; no national instrument implements it. In Nairobi a pan-African hub and data network for disability-inclusive AI was launched with Maseno University's applied AI centre among its partners, and the same centre began onboarding Dholuo speakers for a speech dataset. The central bank published its March 2025 survey on 22 September: half of surveyed institutions had adopted AI, 30 per cent held a formal AI strategy and credit risk assessment was the leading use, at 65 per cent of adopters.

ICT Industry

The Kenyan business of a pan-African backbone owner is repositioning from connectivity provider to a layered artificial-intelligence, cloud and cybersecurity business on top of its own network, its chief executive arguing on 10 September that connectivity becomes the foundation of digital infrastructure rather than the product. He put Africa at 0.6% of world data-centre capacity, the concern he said African telecom executives raise most. It is a stated strategy in two interviews at one conference: no revenue split, investment figure, capacity addition or service launch date accompanies it.

The state's largest telecoms divestment was undone in court and is heading back there. The High Court voided the sale of a 15% Safaricom stake to Vodacom on 15 September, and on 16 September Vodacom said it would appeal and seek a stay, and the finance minister said the Treasury would appeal too. How the proceeds already committed are treated is not on record. A press report of the company's accounts showed the device financier completing its US$8m acquisition of a Finnish device-locking software company.

Innovation ecosystem

An online-work platform launched in 2024 matches businesses to freelancers, uses local cybercafes as access points and settles through mobile money, reporting more than 1,650 users and 200 partner cybercafes; the counts are the company's own.

Capacity

Literacy

The state literacy programme's second phase began putting teacher laptops and smartboards into 10,382 public junior schools, with 91 of 98 Nairobi schools complete, and 1,000 ICT graduates are being recruited as 12-month interns to support it in schools. No learning-outcome measure accompanies either.

On 21 September deliveries of 65-inch smart boards, teacher laptops and ICT equipment began to 178 public junior schools in Nyeri County, under the World Bank-supported digital economy project, towards all 377 in the county. The ICT state department signed a partnership with Intel on 22 September to deliver AI literacy through the public library network, implemented by the national library service; no budget or target is published.

Training and skills

A mathematics and science teacher-training centre ran an international workshop for 100 teachers on 3 and 4 September on digital literacy for competency-based science teaching, its acting chief executive warning against dependence on artificial intelligence in classrooms. No guidance document, cascade plan or teacher-reach target is published behind it.

The largest vocational digitalisation project, some EUR 50m co-financed by KfW, the French development agency and the EU, opened prequalification for its implementation consultant on 22 September, with five years of delivery counted from that consultant's start. A privately run data-centre certification academy launched in Nairobi with a first cohort of five.

Research institutions

On 24 September a regional digital-rights network published its comments on the data regulator's draft guidance notes on AI and on emerging technologies, asking for impact assessments before any biometric processing, audits of platform feed algorithms and a high-risk category for AI in political communication.

Inclusion

Access to services

A UN children's agency report found about one million internet-using Kenyan children exposed to unwanted sexual content online, a rate of 20.1% and the third highest of 21 countries surveyed behind Uganda and Ethiopia, with most child victims knowing their abusers personally, WhatsApp the platform most used to target them, and about 1% of cases reported to police. The findings rest on nationally representative household survey data collected between 2020 and 2025 from children aged 12 to 17. The report itself is not held, only a newspaper account of it.

Digital divides

One programme did reach the refugee-hosting counties: a Dutch-funded course targeting 1,700 refugee and host-community youth in Garissa and Turkana, with more than 700 enrolled from over 1,000 applications.

Data

National statistics

The communications regulator and the University of Nairobi began reviewing preliminary findings from a joint national survey on child online protection and safety on 9 September 2026, with the report structure and thematic areas agreed ahead of validation and the findings intended as the evidence base for regulatory interventions. Neither the sample size nor the fieldwork period is held. The social development directorate drafted a second Inclusive Data Charter action plan for 2026 to 2030, widening the first plan's disability focus to gender, children and older persons.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

Kenya signed a joint declaration with Anthropic at the UN General Assembly, reported on 23 September, covering AI applications in education and health, research, capacity building and AI safety and evaluation. Pilots and institutional partnerships with government agencies are named as the next phase; no funding, timetable or signing date is stated.

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